keep theorists busy. They desperately need to atone for how embarrassing their calculation of dark energy turned out to be.

Do we need an alternative to GR? Does the marriage of GR and quantum mechanics require an overhaul? Or is there some theory of dark energy that awaits discovery by a clever person yet to be born?

A remarkable feature of lambda and the accelerating universe is that the repulsive force arises from within the vacuum, not from anything material. As the vacuum grows, the density of matter and (familiar) energy within the universe diminishes, and the greater becomes lambda's relative influence on the cosmic state of affairs. With greater repulsive pressure comes more vacuum, and with more vacuum comes greater repulsive pressure, forcing an endless and exponential acceleration of the cosmic expansion.

As a consequence, anything not gravitationally bound to the neighborhood of the Milky Way galaxy will recede at ever-increasing speed, as part of the accelerating expansion of the fabric of space-time. Distant galaxies now visible in the night sky will ultimately disappear beyond an unreachable horizon, receding from us faster than the speed of light. A feat allowed, not because they're moving through space at such speeds, but because the fabric of the universe itself carries them at such speeds. No law of physics prevents this.

In a trillion or so years, anyone alive in our own galaxy may know nothing of other galaxies. Our observable universe will merely comprise a system of nearby, long-lived stars within the Milky Way. And beyond this starry night will lie an endless void—darkness in the face of the deep.

Dark energy, a fundamental property of the cosmos, will, in the end, undermine the ability of future generations to comprehend the universe they've been dealt. Unless contemporary astrophysicists across the galaxy keep remarkable records and bury an awesome, trillion-year time capsule, postapocaplyptic scientists will know nothing of galaxies—the principal form of organization for matter in our cosmos—and will thus be denied access to key pages from the cosmic drama that is our universe.

Behold my recurring nightmare: Are we, too, missing some basic pieces of the universe that once were? What part of the cosmic history book has been marked "access denied"? What remains absent from our theories and equations that ought to be there, leaving us groping for answers we may never find?